1986–87

“ CHERNOBYL… SHOWED US A WORLD IN WHICH THE VERY EARTH AND AIR AND WATER FROM WHICH WE DRAW SUSTENANCE LIES POISONED. ”

Satya Das, Canadian author, in speech at the University of Alberta, 1986

Repairs are carried out on the Chernobyl nuclear power plant, after what most consider as the world’s worst ever nuclear accident.

TWO DISASTERS DOMINATED technology news in 1986. In January, NASA’s Space Shuttle *Challenger* broke apart as a result of a **catastrophic explosion** soon after lift-off. All seven astronauts on board were killed—including a civilian, schoolteacher Christine McAuliffe—and the Space Shuttle program was **halted for more than two years**. Three months later, the **Chernobyl nuclear reactor in Ukraine, USSR, exploded** after a power surge during a routine test. Two workers died immediately, and a further 28 in the following few weeks. The area around the reactor was highly contaminated by radioactive material. Around five percent of the obliterated reactor core was carried high into the air after the explosion and the resulting fires spread contamination over a wide area far beyond Ukraine. The accident was attributed to design flaws and inadequate personnel training.

Above Earth’s atmosphere, a Russian Proton-K rocket lifted the first element of the USSR’s **modular space station Mir** into orbit. Over the next decade, another six modules were attached, and a wide range of scientific experiments were conducted in them—including research into the effects of long periods spent in space. Mir was more or less permanently inhabited, by successive crews of astronauts and

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THE NUMBER OF **SECONDS AFTER LIFT OFF** BEFORE SPACE SHUTTLE CHALLENGER **EXPLODED**

Space shuttle tragedy
NASA’s space shuttle Challenger *disintegrates after an explosion shortly after lift-off. All seven astronauts on board the shuttle died.*

January 24, 1986 Space probe Voyager 2’s **closest approach to Uranus**

January 28, 1986 Space Shuttle **Challenger disaster**

February 20, 1986 **In-orbit assembly of Mir** space station begins

March 1986 First field trials of **genetically engineered plants**, in France

March 1986 Five space probes **investigate Halley’s Comet**

April 26, 1986 **Nuclear accident at Chernobyl** nuclear power plant in the Ukraine, Russia

May 5, 1986 **Tau protein identified** as the major component of neurofibrillary tangles associated with **Alzheimer’s disease**

September 1986 IBM develops the first **high-temperature superconductor**

December 5, 1986 IBM researchers invent the **atomic force microscope**